DEPARTMENT HEAD CAMPUS CONVERSATION

# Leading with faculty. Building on momentum.

Leadership philosophy, departmental vision, and academic record

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WHY THIS WORK · WHY HERE

# I know the work.
# I believe in the purpose.

## THE WORK I DO NOW

Professor of Finance and Chair of Accounting and Finance

- Director, Stephen & Gina Surace AI Trading Room
- Principal Investigator, Center for Business and Applied Ethics

**8**
full-time faculty

**7**
programs

**3**
tenure-track lines I helped secure

**$1M**
raised in gifts

## WHAT DRAWS ME HERE

As AI takes on more of the analysis, judgment and leadership become the scarce skills. The Baker School already builds both.

At a senior military college, the work of educating and developing principled leaders is daily practice, not a mission statement.

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 1 OF 7

# Decisions are made *with* faculty.

Consultation must be able to change the outcome.

## UNDERWAY NOW AT SUNY POLY

### Undergraduate curriculum for CPA-120

**FACULTY DECIDE**

How the degree is redesigned for the 120-hour licensure pathway

**MY ROLE**

Frame the constraints, bring the evidence, carry the result forward

### A Master's in Accounting concentration

**FACULTY DECIDE**

Whether the concentration still earns its place

**MY ROLE**

Source alternative online courses so junior faculty can protect research time

*When a decision is made above the department, say so plainly.*

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 2 OF 7

# Make the arithmetic visible.

People can accept a difficult answer. An unexplained one corrodes trust.

SHOWN BEFORE THE DECISION, NOT DEFENDED AFTER

01

## The budget

What we actually have to allocate

02

## The numbers

What enrollment and demand actually say

03

## The constraints

Which are fixed, and which I will fight

> **Course assignments:** a new advisor teaching for the first time took every section of ACC 201, one preparation instead of several. Those sections came from tenure-line faculty. I explained the reasoning first, and they agreed.

**Since 2018** University-Wide Planning and Budget Committee

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 3 OF 7

# Grounded in data, not limited to it.

If only what we measure counts, everything we cannot measure becomes irrelevant by default.

IN PRACTICE

## Build the data we need.

I started collecting employment outcomes for our students. They showed a pipeline of finance graduates into Lockheed Martin in Syracuse, some in supply chain roles.

## Reason openly about the rest.

How CPA-120 will change graduate accounting enrollment: no data yet, and the decision cannot wait.

*What we cannot measure still counts.*

LEADERSHIP PHILOSOPHY · 4 OF 7

# Faculty time is a fixed budget.

Adding tasks is easy. That is not management.

## HOW I MANAGE IT

### If I add a task, I take one away.

CPA-120 meant a stack of curriculum committee forms for the accounting faculty. In exchange, I got them off a university-wide service committee.

### Streamline what already exists.

Faculty reported publications, teaching, and service separately to the dean, the provost, AACSB, and Middle States. I cut that to one report.

*Management is making room for the work that matters.*

# Tell people the truth early.

A colleague who first learns at the decision that the record was at risk was failed by everyone who saw it earlier.

**YEAR ONE**

## Explain the process

The written standards and where committee judgment enters

**YEARS TWO AND THREE**

## Give a candid midpoint read

Teaching and publication risks, not just totals

**BEFORE RENEWAL AND TENURE**

## No false assurances

Advocate without pretending to control the outcome

> Throughout: protect time — Shield pre-tenure faculty from service that crowds out the record

**No head can promise an outcome.** A head can make the risks visible early.

# Advocate for what faculty need.

Time and money for scholarship, argued for upward.

**WHAT I HAVE SECURED FOR FACULTY**

### Research funds

More support for the costs of doing research.

### Course releases

Teaching time returned to faculty with active research agendas.

### Aligned committee assignments

Committee assignments aligned with research activity and workload.

> **Nothing is free** More research funds came with higher research expectations. I say so up front.

# The head owns the response.

When results fall short, accountability means making sure evidence leads to action.

**68%**

met benchmark
Spring 2022

**DIAGNOSE**

Quantitative skill was the constraint

**ACT TOGETHER**

Brief practice across the curriculum

**80%**

met benchmark
2023–24

Same instrument. +12 points. Highest recorded result.

LEADERSHIP IN PRACTICE · FUNDRAISING

# Raise the resources. Then make them academic.

**$250K**

lead gift

**RECRUIT**

Matching donors

**$1M**

raised

**FUNDED**

AI Trading Room and the NYSTEC Business Center of Excellence

The harder work came after

5 courses · FinTech Club · 100+ students · 2 industry partners

**$200K SUNY grant** Center for Business and Applied Ethics, as Principal Investigator

# Growth comes from program design.

**+50%**

Finance enrollment
over five years

**Steady**

Accounting, through
CPA licensure shifts

**PROGRAMS I HAVE BUILT OR LED**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **2015** | Online MBA, Finance concentration | Clarion · built the curriculum |
| **2015** | M.S. Applied Data Analytics | Clarion · coordinated curriculum |
| **2019** | B.S. Finance | SUNY Poly · coordinator since 2020 |
| **2022** | M.S. Data Science and Analytics | SUNY Poly · committee member |
| **2025** | Ph.D. in Data Analytics | SUNY Poly · chair, under review |

One system, not three problems

curriculum · advising · recruiting · employers and alumni in the building

# Momentum is already visible.

Student-Managed Investment Fund

Rick and Mary Lee Bastin Financial Leadership Lab

Bastin Hall

Faculty work with generative AI

AACSB accreditation

HOW WE WOULD GET THERE

# Listen first. Earn the right to scale.

FIRST 90 DAYS

## Listen, map, return

- Faculty, students, staff, partners
- Map commitments and constraints
- Return what I heard, and where views differ

YEAR ONE

## Choose and pilot

- Faculty choose the questions
- Define evidence of success
- Run bounded pilots

YEAR TWO

## Scale or retire

- Scale what the evidence supports
- Resource faculty ownership
- Retire what did not, and say so

External engagement is the supporting layer

donors · advisory board · placements · capstones · regional partners

OPPORTUNITY TO EXPLORE · 1

# A resilient accounting pipeline

### CPA-120 AT SUNY POLY · SEPT. 2026

**0** new courses needed to meet New York's 120-hour pathway

ACC 312 Accounting Systems
now required, for accounting information systems

FIN 420 Financial Analytics
now required, for business data analytics

30 accounting credits (27 req.) · 23 upper-division (18 req.)

### QUESTIONS TO EXPLORE HERE

**LICENSURE**
How should changing pathways shape advising?

**PROGRESSION**
Does the year a master's saves justify a graduate option here?

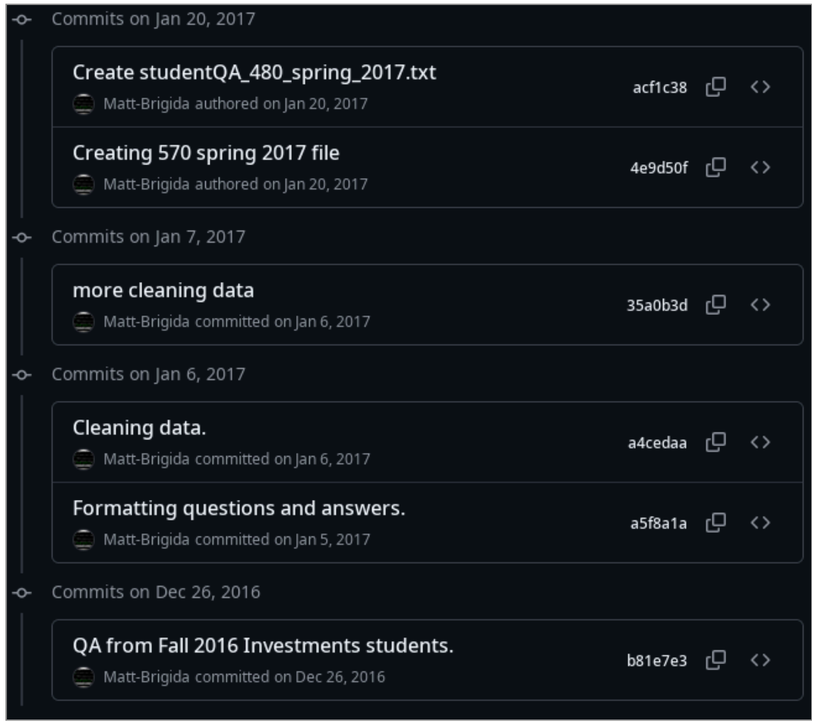
**CURRICULUM**
Where does analytics add real accounting value?

On accounting matters, I would lean on the accounting colleagues who own the expertise.

South Carolina, since June 30, 2025 Bachelor's + 2 years' experience, or master's or 150 hours + 1 year · exam window 18 to 36 months

BEFORE THE AI OPPORTUNITIES

# I have been building this for over a decade.




**First public commit: December 26, 2016** · my students' questions

**github.com/matt-brigida** Public code and data

FINANCE AI TEACHING ASSISTANT · SEQ2SEQ LSTM

Q What is a put option?

`the right to sell a specific stock for a specified period of time`

Q What is the risk free rate?

`The interest rate that can be earned with certainty`

Q What is Apple Inc ticker symbol?

`It is known as their option.` Confident. Wrong.

OPPORTUNITY TO EXPLORE · 2

# An AI-augmented investment fund

THE CITADEL'S PLATFORM

## SMIF + Financial Leadership Lab

EXPLORE TOGETHER

EXPERIENCE I BRING

## Director, AI Trading Room

5 courses · 100+ students · 2 partners

RESEARCH QUESTIONS THE LAB COULD TEST

**BEHAVIOR**

Does AI advice correct investor irrationality, or does the prompt induce it?

**STEERING**

Do models nudge investors toward particular products or strategies?

**DUTY**

Does an AI “fiduciary” make sense, and what would it owe?

*The aim is judgment with better tools, not judgment handed to tools.*

OPPORTUNITY TO EXPLORE · 3

# AI in our DNA: transform in place

Make existing courses AI-native instead of bolting on new ones.

### ILLUSTRATION FROM THE PROPOSAL · FIVE EXISTING COURSES

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Add new AI courses | 10 COURSES | +1 FACULTY LINE | High COST |
| Transform in place | 5 COURSES | 0 NEW FACULTY | Low COST |

### EXAMPLE TRANSFORMATIONS

Introduction to Business
→ AI in Business

Management Information Systems
→ Cloud and AI Systems

Financial Markets and Institutions
→ Digital Finance: Markets and Institutions

**Why it matters** Every new course draws on the same qualified faculty, and AACSB sufficiency limits how far they can stretch.

**My proposal** Submitted to the SUNY Poly College of Business

OPPORTUNITY TO EXPLORE · 4

# Defining teaching effectiveness together

The criteria should be developed with faculty before they affect faculty qualification.

+ Faculty-owned criteria aligned with mission
+ Multiple forms of evidence, not one metric
+ Expectations, feedback, and support in writing

AACSB 2026 · EFFECTIVE JULY 2026

## Standard 3.2

Teaching effectiveness becomes part of SA, PA, SP, and IP qualification.

40% SA | 90% SA+PA+SP+IP

Three-year ramp-up · evaluated from 2029–30

A PAUSE BEFORE THE RECORD

# Questions on leadership and vision?

## HOW I LEAD

- Decisions are made with faculty
- Make the arithmetic visible
- Grounded in data, not limited to it
- Faculty time is a fixed budget
- Tell people the truth early
- Advocate for what faculty need
- Own the response when results fall short

## IN PRACTICE

- $1M raised, then made academic
- Finance enrollment up 50% in five years

## OPPORTUNITIES TO EXPLORE

- A resilient accounting pipeline
- An AI-augmented investment fund
- AI in our DNA: transform in place
- Defining teaching effectiveness together

TEACHING

# Remain close to the classroom.

Learn the concept, then test it on real market data right away.

**2**
courses each semester while chair

**4.3/5**
excellent teacher, 32 reports

**4.9 · 4.8**
two most recent sections

### 15 Python notebooks
Financial Analytics, with companion videos

### Interactive R/Shiny apps
Built for the Milken Institute's 5MinuteFinance

### Course databases
Tokenized stocks and perps, FDIC Call Reports, Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac loans

### Short video lectures
Alumni return to them before CFA and Series 63 exams

*Experiential, analytically serious, and attentive to what students can demonstrate.*

SCHOLARSHIP

# Keep inquiry active and connected.

**26 peer-reviewed articles** Publishing continuously through the chairship

CRYPTO

## Pricing and risk in cryptocurrency markets

Finance Research Letters 2026 · Economics Letters 2025 · Applied Finance Letters 2023

ENERGY

## Natural gas, oil, and electricity pricing and volatility

Energy Economics · Journal of Energy Markets · IAEE/USAEE Best Working Paper

BANKING

## Capital, risk, and bank safety

Managerial Finance 2025 · Applied Finance Letters 2022 · Banking and Finance Review 2019

SCHOLARSHIP · RESEARCH INFRASTRUCTURE

# Build the data the questions need.

CRYPTO

## Tokenized stocks and perpetual futures

Across multiple decentralized and centralized exchanges, for cross-venue research on stock-based crypto assets

ENERGY

## EIA data wrappers

Python and R access to the U.S. Energy Information Administration API; the R package is on CRAN

BANKING

## Every FDIC-insured institution

Financial data merged with FFIEC institution data

**Why now** SEC Innovation Exemption, September 17, 2026: temporary, conditional relief for certain tokenized NMS stocks on permissioned venues

SCHOLARSHIP · IN PROGRESS

# Research that follows live questions.

### CRYPTO

The TVL Mirage: TVL Interactions, Ecosystem Activity, and Cryptocurrency Returns

### ENERGY

Natural Gas Pipeline Constraints, Market Integration, and Flaring

Diversification in Electricity Price and Volume Swaps (forthcoming)

### BANKING

Hedging Deposit Run Risk Prior to the 2023 Regional Banking Crisis

Cross-Sectional Variation in Uninsured Deposits (under review)

The Determinants of Uninsured Deposits

Regulatory Capital Levels and Noninterest Income

Account Fees at Minority-Owned Depository Institutions

*Seven working papers, one under review, plus one forthcoming article.*

INDUSTRY ENGAGEMENT

# Bring practice into the department.

**2025 TO PRESENT**

## Algorand Foundation

Chief Economist

Factor pricing models and cryptocurrency risk premia

**2022 TO 2023**

## Huntington Bank

Advisor, Treasury Analytics and Modeling

Term-structure forecasting and short-rate models for derivative valuation

**2014 TO 2021**

## Milken Institute

Financial Education Advisor

Applied research and interactive financial-education tools

**2009**

## NextEra Energy Resources

Business Management Analyst

Valuation of natural-gas-fired generation assets

**What it produces for the department**

course material · placements · capstone projects · advisory board members · donors

SERVICE

# Build structures that let others succeed.

## Assessment and accreditation

Chair, College of Business Assurance of Learning (2024 to present) · AACSB Steering Committee (2018)

## University governance

Planning and Budget Committee (2018 to present) · College Leadership Committee (2020 to present) · Dean Search Committee (2018)

# Listen before setting direction.
# Make the reasoning visible.
# Build with the faculty.

Build on momentum. Explore deliberately. Own the outcome.

QUESTIONS AND CONVERSATION